

V1 Vulnerability Circle

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-60 minutes	Group Size	4-12 (optimal: 6-8)
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (this is a foundation exercise)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Low vulnerability scores, declining trust indicators, team reluctance to raise issues or admit mistakes

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

When someone shares something vulnerable and the group responds with acceptance rather than judgment, the brain releases oxytocin (the trust chemical) and dials down cortisol (the stress hormone). The amygdala, your brain's threat detector, recalibrates: it learns that this group is safe.

This is not a one-time effect. Each positive vulnerability exchange strengthens the neural pathways associated with trust. Over time, the team's baseline threat response lowers, making collaboration, risk-taking, and honest communication easier at a biological level.

The reverse is also true. In teams where vulnerability is punished or ignored, cortisol stays elevated, the amygdala stays on alert, and people default to self-protection: withholding ideas, hiding mistakes, avoiding difficult conversations.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"Our brains are wired to protect us from social risk. That's useful, but it also means we hold back ideas, avoid tough conversations, and hide mistakes. This exercise helps the team build enough trust that we can lower those defences. The research shows that teams who practice this kind of openness make better decisions, catch problems earlier, and perform at a higher level."

Before You Begin

Materials

In-Person	Remote
Sticky notes (one pad per person) Pens Flipchart or whiteboard Timer visible to room	Miro board (pre-set with sections) or Teams/Zoom chat Digital timer (share screen) Breakout rooms configured (pairs)

	Camera on (strongly recommended)
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PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY CHECK

Do NOT run this exercise if any of the following are true:

- The team has experienced layoffs, restructuring, or significant personnel changes within the past 3 weeks
- There is an active, unresolved conflict between team members that has not been addressed
- A team member is currently on a performance improvement plan (discuss with HR whether their participation is appropriate)
- You (the manager) are not prepared to be vulnerable first

If in doubt, start with V8 (Balancing Personal and Professional Vulnerability) as a lighter entry point.

Manager Self-Preparation

Before facilitating this exercise, prepare your own vulnerability share. You will go first. This is non-negotiable: if the manager does not model vulnerability, the team will not follow.

Your share should be:

- Genuine (not rehearsed to the point of feeling safe and polished)
- Work-relevant (a professional struggle, a mistake, something you found difficult)
- Appropriately bounded (not a personal crisis or something that would make your team worry about your competence)
- Recent enough to feel real (not a story from 10 years ago that has been fully resolved)

CALIBRATION GUIDE

Too safe: "I sometimes struggle with time management." (Everyone says this. It costs nothing.)

Right level: "Last month I made a call on the project timeline that I now think was wrong, and I didn't flag it early enough because I didn't want to look like I didn't have it under control."

Too much: "I'm not sure I'm the right person to be managing this team." (Creates anxiety rather than trust.)

The Exercise**Phase 1: Opening (5 minutes)****WHAT TO SAY**

"Today we're going to do something different. I'm going to ask everyone, including me, to share something that we normally keep to ourselves at work. This isn't about therapy or oversharing. It's

about building the kind of trust where we can be honest with each other about the things that actually matter."

"Everything shared in this room stays in this room. There are no right or wrong answers. And I'm going to go first."

Set the ground rules:

- Confidentiality: nothing shared leaves this room
- No advice-giving: we listen, we acknowledge, we do not fix
- No judgment: verbal or nonverbal (watch for eye-rolls, crossed arms, phone-checking)
- Participation is encouraged but not forced: anyone can pass

Phase 2: Manager Models (5 minutes)

Share your prepared vulnerability. Aim for 60-90 seconds. Do not over-explain or add a tidy resolution. End with something honest, not a lesson learned.

WHAT TO SAY (AFTER YOUR SHARE)

"That felt uncomfortable to say out loud. And that's kind of the point. I wanted to go first because I think it's important that you see me being honest about the things I find difficult, not just the things I've figured out."

FACILITATION NOTE

After you share, pause. Do not immediately invite others to share. Let the silence sit for 5-8 seconds. This pause signals that you are not performing; you meant it. The team is processing both the content and the fact that their manager just did something unexpected.

Phase 3: Individual Preparation (5 minutes)

Give each person time to prepare their share privately. This is critical: asking people to share cold produces either refusal or performative responses.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'd like you to take 5 minutes to think about something you'd be willing to share. It could be a work challenge you've been sitting with, a mistake you haven't talked about, or something you're finding difficult right now. Write it down for yourself. You'll decide what you want to share out loud, and how much."

During this time: stay quiet. Do not walk around. Do not check your phone. Sit with the same discomfort you're asking them to sit with.

Phase 4: Sharing Round (20-30 minutes)

Invite volunteers rather than going round-robin. Forced sharing creates resentment; volunteering builds genuine trust.

WHAT TO SAY

"Who'd like to go next? There's no order. Take your time."

After each share, the manager's response follows the same pattern:

1. Acknowledge: "Thank you for sharing that." (Genuine, brief.)
2. Validate: name what you heard without interpreting. "It sounds like that's been weighing on you" or "That took courage to say."
3. Do NOT: give advice, relate it to your own experience, or try to solve it.
4. Invite the group: "Does anyone want to respond?" (If the group adds supportive comments, let it flow naturally. If not, move on. Do not force connection.)

WHAT IF SOMEONE PASSES?

Respect it completely. "No problem at all. Thank you." Move on without hesitation or visible disappointment. Checking in privately afterward is fine: "I just wanted to make sure you're okay. No pressure to share anything." A pass is not a failure. It may mean the trust is not yet there, or the timing is wrong, or the person is processing something they are not ready to voice. All of these are valid.

Phase 5: Synthesis (5-10 minutes)

Do not ask "what did you learn?" This creates pressure to produce a neat takeaway from an emotional exercise. Instead:

WHAT TO SAY

"I want to thank everyone for what was shared today. I'm not going to ask you to summarise or draw conclusions. What I am going to ask is one simple question: having heard all of that, is there anything you'd do differently going forward?"

Pause. Let responses come naturally. If none come, that is fine. Say: "That's okay. Sometimes the most important changes happen quietly."

Phase 6: Close (2-3 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"What happened in this room stays in this room. What I'd ask is that you carry the spirit of it forward. If you're struggling with something, or you see a colleague struggling, let's make it easier to say so."

"I'm going to follow up with each of you individually over the next week. Not to check up on you, just to

check in."

Then end the meeting. Do not add agenda items or transition to other business. The exercise needs its own container.

Facilitation Notes

In addition to the five standard contingencies (silence, emotional escalation, dominant participant, topic avoidance, performative compliance), this exercise has the following specific risks:

Situation	Response
Someone shares something that suggests they need professional support (e.g., mental health, harassment, safety)	Do not try to counsel them. Acknowledge what they said. After the session, speak to them privately: "I'm glad you shared that. I want to make sure you get the right support. Can I connect you with [HR/EAP/appropriate resource]?" If you believe there is an immediate safety concern, follow your organisation's safeguarding protocols.
Someone uses the exercise to criticise another team member (directly or indirectly)	Redirect immediately but without shaming: "I hear that this is a frustration. For this exercise, let's keep the focus on our own experiences rather than others' behaviour. We can address team dynamics separately." Follow up privately with both parties after the session.
The shares are all surface-level and safe ("I sometimes find meetings frustrating")	This is not a failure for a first session. Surface-level sharing in round one is the amygdala doing its job. Do not push for depth. Run the exercise again in 4-6 weeks. Depth increases with repeated exposure to safety. If you want to gently invite more depth: after a surface share, say "Thank you. Is there anything underneath that you'd be comfortable adding?" Accept whatever answer you get.
One person's share triggers a strong reaction in another person	This can happen when someone's vulnerability resonates deeply with another team member. Acknowledge it: "It looks like that connected with you. Would you like to say something, or would you prefer to sit with it?" Do not pressure them to explain their reaction. Check in privately afterward.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Shares become progressively more honest as the round continues Body language shifts from guarded (arms crossed, leaning back) to open People make eye contact with the speaker rather than looking at the floor Spontaneous supportive comments from other team members (not prompted by you)
Within 1-2 weeks	A team member raises a concern or mistake in a regular meeting that they would previously have kept quiet Conversations between team members feel slightly less guarded Someone references the session positively ("like we talked about in that exercise")
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Vulnerability pillar scores increase Qualitative responses show language around trust, openness, or safety Communication scores may also lift (vulnerability and communication are tightly linked)
Red flags	If vulnerability scores DROP after the exercise, the session may have felt unsafe to some participants. Action: follow up individually with each team member. Ask "How did that exercise land for you?" and listen without defending.

Remote/Hybrid Adaptation

Element	Remote Modification
Cameras	Strongly request cameras on. Frame it as: "I'm asking everyone to have cameras on for this session so we can see each other. It matters for this kind of conversation." Do not force it.
Preparation phase	Use a private Miro board or ask people to write in their own notebook. The chat function is NOT appropriate for sensitive content, as it creates a permanent record.
Sharing round	Keep the full group together (no breakout rooms). The manager needs to be present for every share to manage the emotional tone. Mute notifications and close other applications. Ask participants to do the same.
After-session check-in	Individual check-ins are even more important remotely, as you lose the informal corridor conversations that happen naturally after an in-person session. Schedule 10-minute one-to-ones within the following week.
Timing	Add 10-15 minutes to total time. Online sessions need longer preparation time and more deliberate transitions between phases.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V2: Failure Stories	Builds on the trust established in V1 by focusing specifically on sharing professional mistakes.	Run after V1 (allow 2-4 weeks gap)
V8: Balancing Vulnerability	A lighter alternative if the team is not ready for V1. Covers boundary-setting and appropriate levels of sharing.	Can be run before V1 as a warm-up for cautious teams
C9: Conflict Communication	Vulnerability is a prerequisite for honest conflict resolution. Teams that have not done V1 will struggle with C9.	Run V1 before C9
C15: Feedback Culture	Giving and receiving honest feedback requires the trust that V1 establishes.	Run V1 before C15
R1: Micro-Reflection	Reflection prompts can reinforce vulnerability practice between sessions.	Complementary (run alongside)